

# DECODED EXPLAINED

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# Higher Education Faces Three Challenges



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## Higher education faces three challenges

WHY DO Indian institutions not feature among the world's top universities in major global rankings? Why have universities in China, Singapore and Hong Kong climbed to the top in these lists even though only a few decades ago they were on par with India?

There is considerable discussion about the poor state of our higher education system, as well as the low employability of many college graduates. The usual explanations cite inadequate funding, excessive regulation, poor infrastructure and flawed policies. These factors do not fully explain the problem. Indians in and outside of India have demonstrated world-class capability in science, technology, medicine, entrepreneurship and research. Our challenge is not a lack of talent, nor simply resources. The real barriers, in my view, lie deeper. They can be understood through three challenges: Intention, concept, and execution.

The first is whether we consistently place merit, integrity, fairness, and the long-term interests of institutions above other considerations. In too many cases, appointments, promotions and admissions are swayed by factors that should have no place in decision-making. We cannot appoint favourites, regardless of merit, to responsible positions and expect good results. Students can sense favouritism and dishonesty, and they learn not only from what we teach but also from how we conduct ourselves.

**A culture driven by fear of failure discourages initiative; a culture that learns from failure fosters innovation and experimentation**

We must ensure that we are solving the right problems in the right way. Universities are neither government departments nor corporate offices. They are unique learning communities and therefore require distinct governance models. Misunderstanding the nature of a university can lead to well-intentioned policies that are ultimately counterproductive. For instance, faculty members at many of our public universities are appointed on a one-year probationary basis. One year is inadequate to assess a candidate's suitability.

Universities cannot develop responsible adults if they treat students as children. Institutions cannot be expected to excel if they are denied autonomy while being held accountable for outcomes. Academic excellence is unlikely to flourish under excessive control; it requires trust, responsibility and a shared commitment to institutional goals.

Similarly, it is difficult to justify applying the same faculty recruitment and promotion policies across diverse institutions and disciplines. Policies should recognise differences among large and small institutions, among teaching-focused and research-focused institutions, and among

universities in favourable environments and those in difficult geographies. A faculty member in the sciences cannot always be assessed by the same criteria as one in the liberal arts, while the performing arts may require an entirely different framework.

If universities are to nurture excellence, their governance systems must recognise the distinctive nature of academic work, institutional contexts, disciplinary cultures, and local realities. Even with the best intentions, we still face the challenge of ensuring effective execution. Building great academic institutions requires capable leaders, robust processes, continuous learning, and the humility to learn from mistakes. A culture driven by fear of failure discourages initiative; a culture that learns from failure fosters innovation and experimentation. We must also invest in developing academic leaders through systematic coaching and mentoring. Good ideas do not implement themselves. Leaders need the knowledge, skills, confidence, and institutional support to translate sound ideas into effective practices.

Higher education cannot improve through isolated islands of excellence. Weak institutions tend to pull down stronger ones, partly because policies are often designed to address the weakest institutions and then imposed uniformly across the system, and partly because faculty, non-teaching staff, and students move across the system.

We need to take a serious look at how we govern and support our higher education institutions. Funding, infrastructure, and regulation matter, but they will not be sufficient unless we also address the deeper challenges of intention, concept, and execution.

*The writer was V-C, Banaras Hindu University and founder-director, IIT Gandhinagar*

## Higher Education Faces Three Challenges

- **The Core Question**

- Why do Indian institutions not feature among the world's top universities in major global rankings? Why have universities in China, Singapore and Hong Kong climbed to the top even though only a few decades ago they were on par with India?

- The usual explanations cite inadequate funding, excessive regulation, poor infrastructure and flawed policies; these factors do not fully explain the problem, since Indians in and outside India have demonstrated world-class capability in science, technology, medicine, entrepreneurship and research

- The real barriers lie deeper, understood through three challenges: Intention, Concept, and Execution

## Higher Education Faces Three Challenges

### ● Challenge 1: Intention

- The first challenge is whether we consistently place merit, integrity, fairness, and the long-term interests of institutions above other considerations; in too many cases, appointments, promotions and admissions are swayed by factors that should have no place in decision-making
- We cannot appoint favourites, regardless of merit, to responsible positions and expect good results; students can sense favouritism and dishonesty, and they learn not only from what we teach but also from how we conduct ourselves

## Higher Education Faces Three Challenges

- **Challenge 2: Concept**

- **We must ensure we are solving the right problems in the right way; universities are neither government departments nor corporate offices, they are unique learning communities and therefore require distinct governance models**

- **For instance, faculty members at many public universities are appointed on a one-year probationary basis, which is inadequate to assess a candidate's suitability; universities cannot develop responsible adults if they treat students as children, and institutions cannot excel if denied autonomy while being held accountable for outcomes**

- **It is difficult to justify applying the same faculty recruitment and promotion policies across diverse institutions and disciplines; policies should recognise differences among large and small institutions, teaching-focused and research-focused institutions, and those in favourable versus difficult geographies**

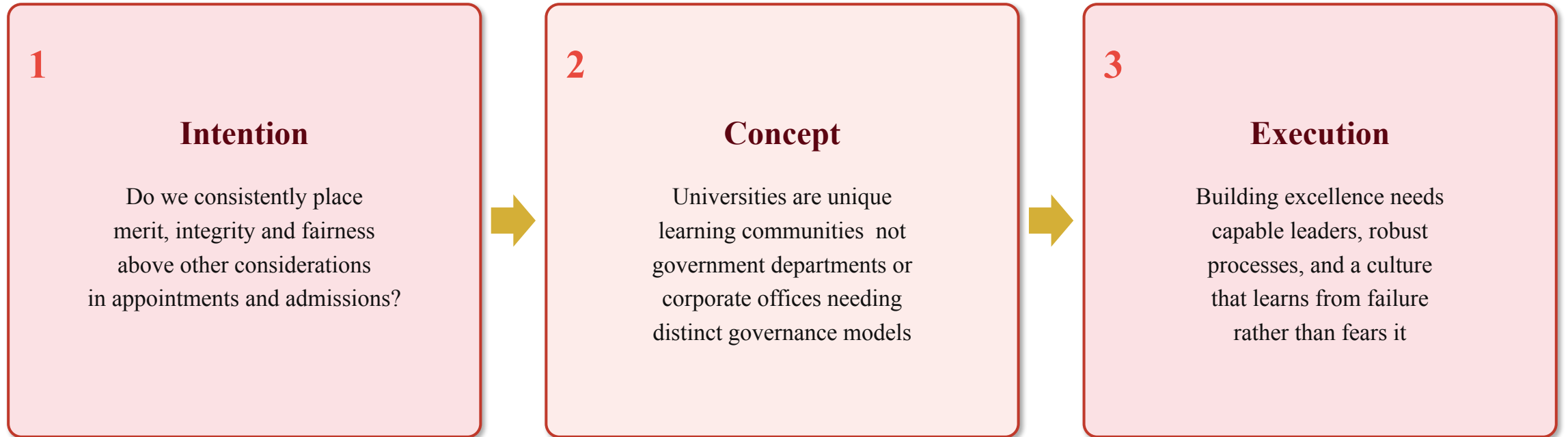
## Higher Education Faces Three Challenges

- **Challenge 3: Execution**

- If universities are to nurture excellence, their governance systems must recognise the distinctive nature of academic work, institutional contexts, disciplinary cultures, and local realities
- **Building great academic institutions requires capable leaders, robust processes, continuous learning, and the humility to learn from mistakes; a culture driven by fear of failure discourages initiative, while a culture that learns from failure fosters innovation and experimentation**

# Higher Education Faces Three Challenges

## Three Deeper Challenges Facing Indian Higher Education



# Southern African Customs Bloc, India Revive Trade Talks

## Southern African Customs bloc, India revive trade talks

**Reuters**

NEW DELHI

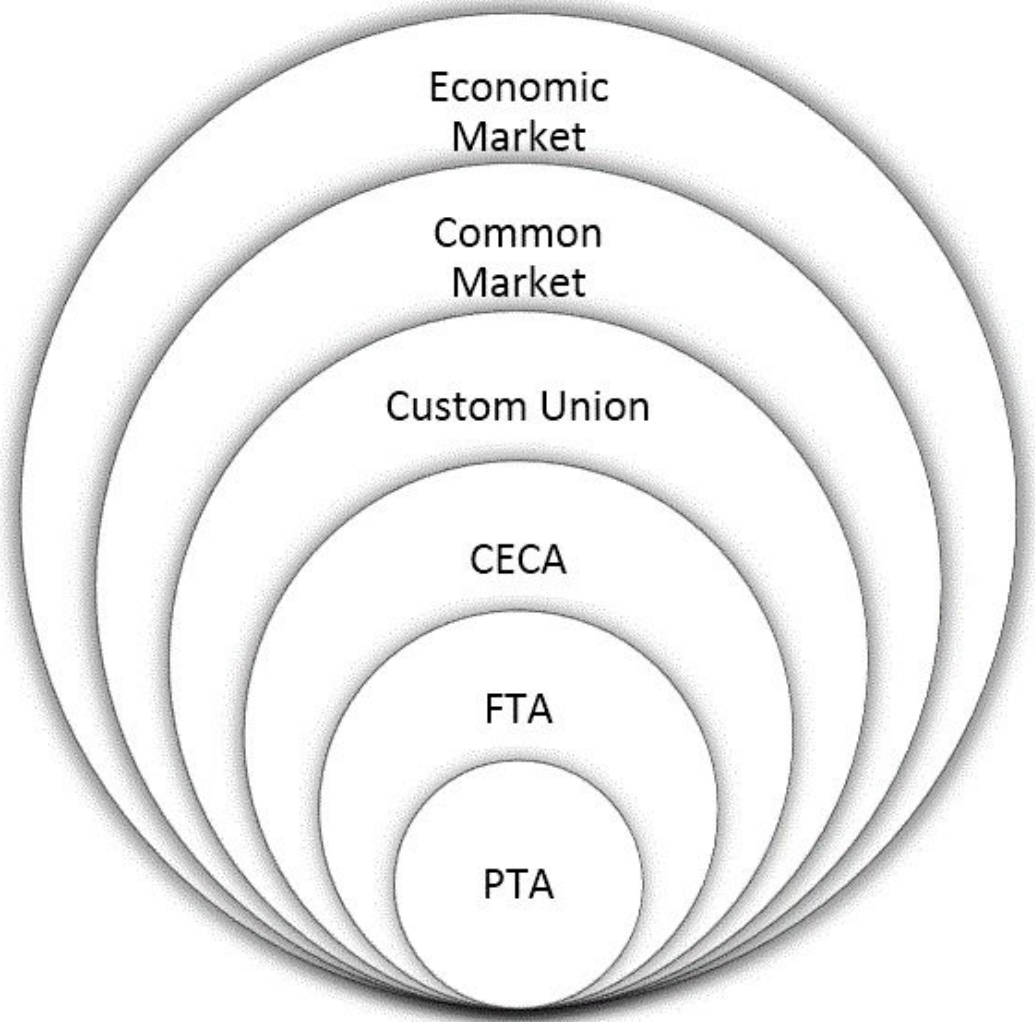
India and the five-member Southern African Customs Union signed terms of reference on Wednesday to start talks on a preferential trade agreement, as New Delhi seeks lower tariffs on exports including cars, pharmaceuticals and industrial machinery.

The move revives talks between India and SACU, comprising South Africa, Botswana, Namibia, Lesotho and Eswatini, after five rounds of negotiations between 2002 and 2010 ended without a deal.

The pact could become India's first major trade agreement with an African regional bloc, giving Indian companies preferential access to a market of about 65 million people.

Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal said he was confident SACU countries and India would "benefit immensely" from a fair, equitable and balanced agreement.

## The problem with India's free trade agreement strategy

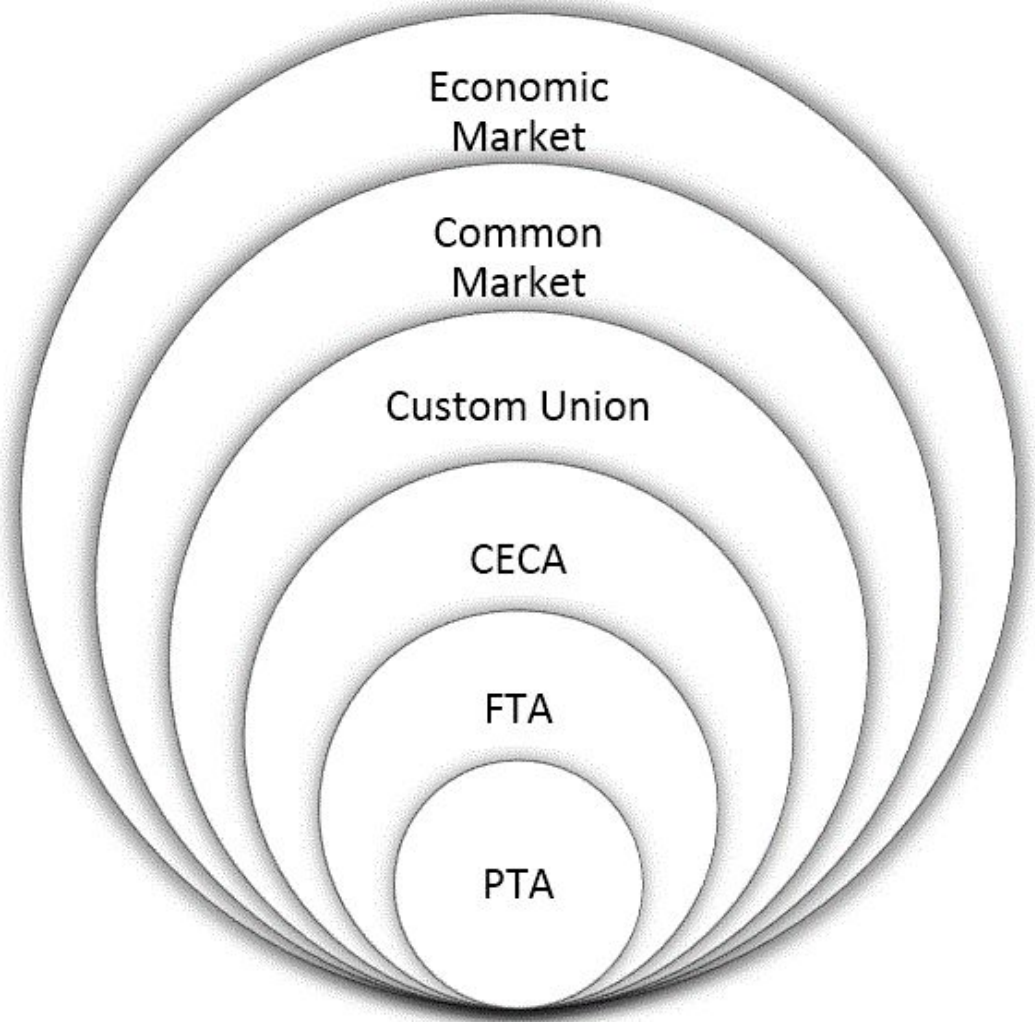


A preferential trade agreement, is a trading bloc that gives preferential access to certain products from the participating countries. India-Mercosur Preferential Trade Agreement (PTA): Mercosur is a sub-regional blocs with its member countries – full members are Argentina, Brazil, Paraguay, Uruguay and Bolivia

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## The problem with India's free trade agreement strategy



A free-trade area is a trade bloc whose member countries have signed a free-trade agreement (FTA), which eliminates tariffs, import quotas, and preferences on most (if not all) goods and services traded between them.

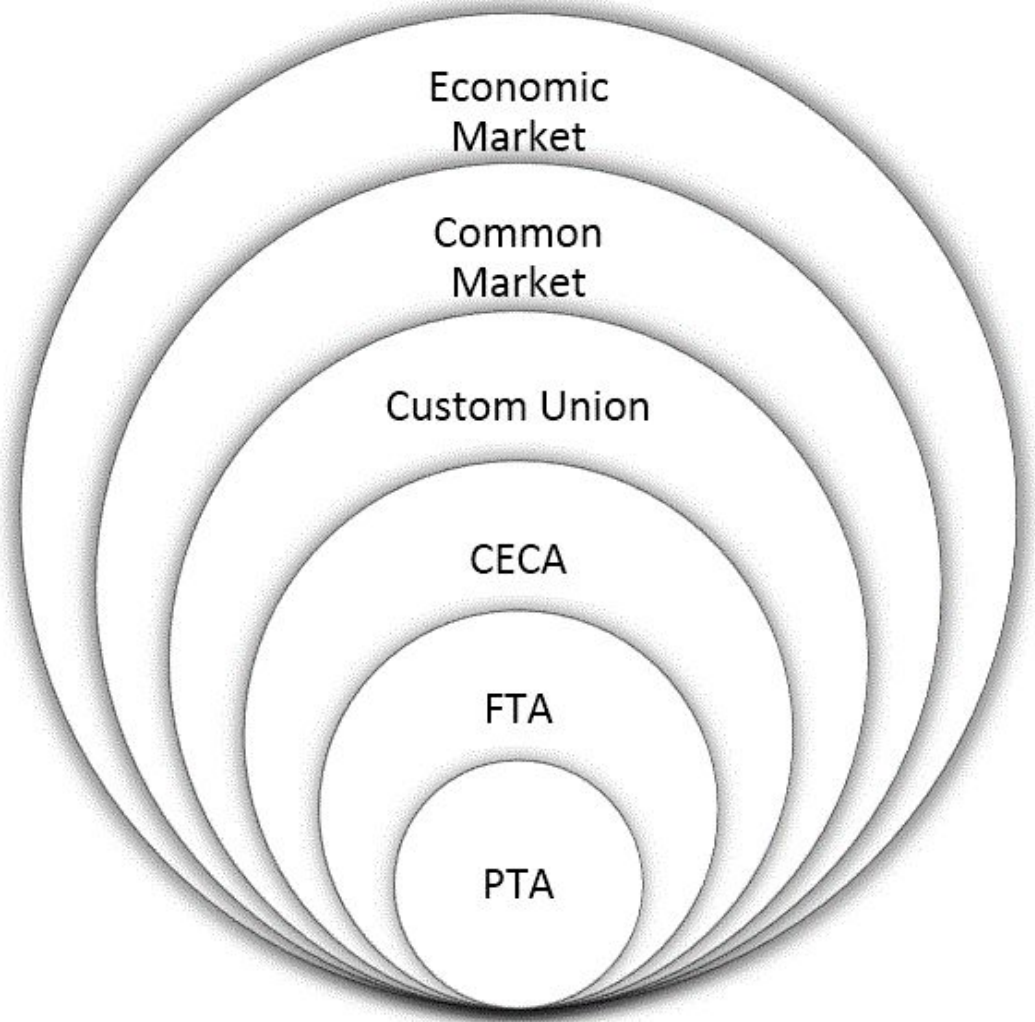
When the countries go beyond FTA and agree for a greater degree of economic integration which includes improving the attractiveness to capital and human resources, and to expand trade and investment, it would result in CECA or CEPA.

**CEPA = Comprehensive Economic partnership Agreement**

**CECA = Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement**

**CEPA has a bit wider scope than CECA.**

## The problem with India's free trade agreement strategy



### Customs Union

An agreement among countries to have free trade among themselves and to adopt common external barriers against any other country interested in exporting to these countries.

**Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC)** – Its member states are Bahrain, Kuwait, Oman, Qatar, Saudi Arabia, and the United Arab Emirates

### Common Market

A type of custom union where there are common policies on product regulation, and free movement of goods and services, capital and labour.

### Economic and monetary union :

When an union involves unifying currency it becomes a economic and monetary union. Eg – Euro

## **Southern African Customs Bloc, India Revive Trade Talks**

### **● The Development**

- India and the five-member Southern African Customs Union signed terms of reference on Wednesday to start talks on a preferential trade agreement, as New Delhi seeks lower tariffs on exports including cars, pharmaceuticals and industrial machinery
- The move revives talks between India and SACU, comprising South Africa, Botswana, Namibia, Lesotho and Eswatini, after five rounds of negotiations between 2002 and 2010 ended without a deal

### **● Significance**

- The pact could become India's first major trade agreement with an African regional bloc, giving Indian companies preferential access to a market of about 65 million people
- Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal said he was confident SACU countries and India would 'benefit immensely' from a fair, equitable and balanced agreement

## Southern African Customs Bloc, India Revive Trade Talks

SACU is the world's oldest customs union, established in 1910, re-established in 1969 with the current agreement.

Five member states: Botswana, Eswatini, Lesotho, Namibia, and South Africa.

Headquarters located in Windhoek, Namibia;

### Namibia :

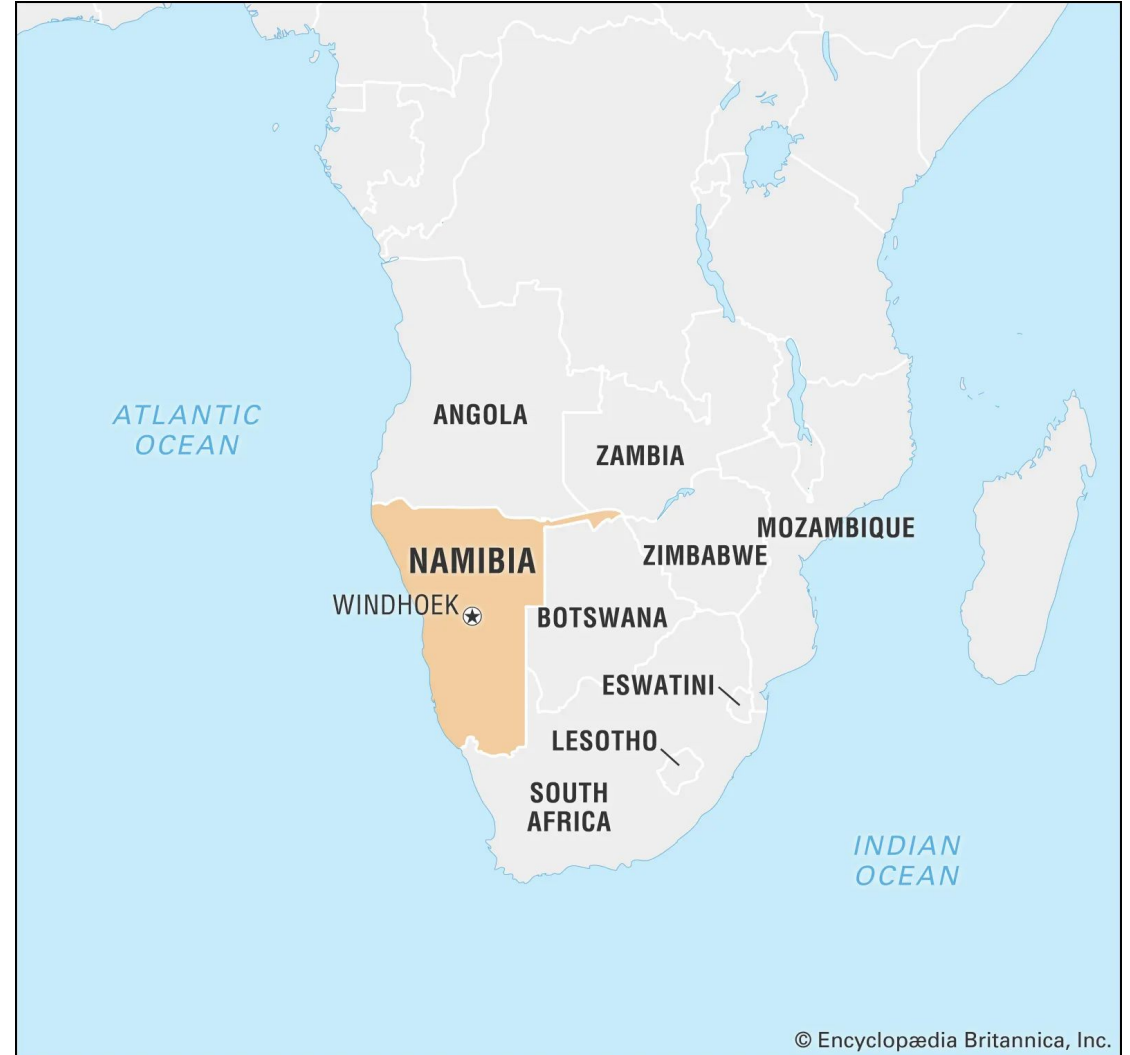
Neighboring Countries: Angola (north), Zambia (northeast), Botswana (east), and South Africa (southeast and south).

Bordered by The Atlantic Ocean to the west.

Landforms: the coastal Namib desert, the Central Plateau, and the Kalahari Desert.

Major Rivers: Zambezi, Mashi, Orange River (drains into the Atlantic Ocean) etc.

Zambezi river drains into the Indian Ocean. It cuts the Tropic of Capricorn twice in Africa.



## Southern African Customs Bloc, India Revive Trade Talks

### Namib Desert

Oldest desert on Earth

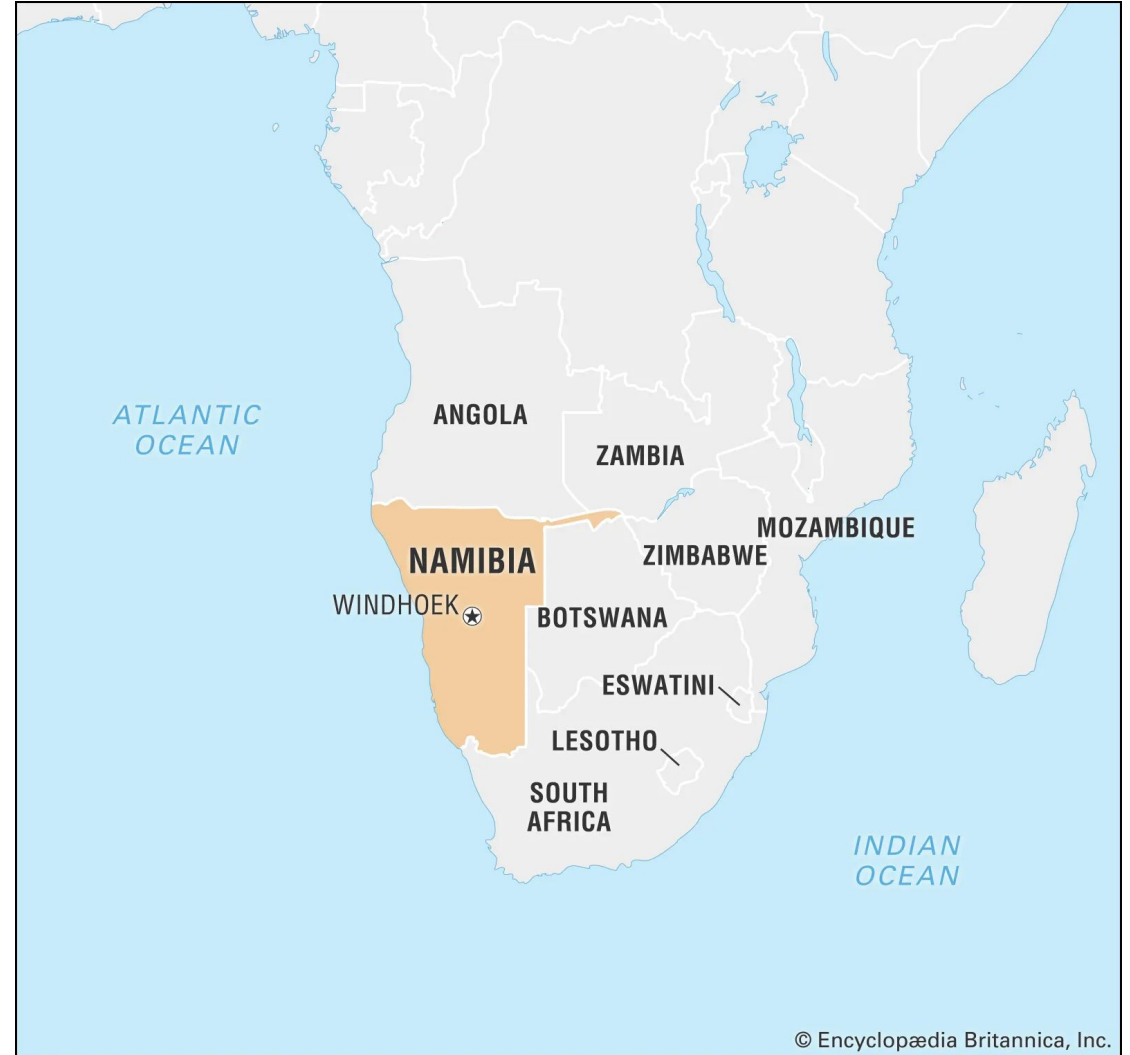
### Hoba Meteorite

It has been uncovered, but because of its large mass, has never been moved from where it fell. Heaviest Meteorite

### Etosha Pan

Etosha Pan, extremely flat salt pan, northern Namibia, covering an area of approximately 1,900 square miles (4,800 square km) at an elevation of about 3,400 feet (1,030 m). This enormous expanse of salt, glimmering green in the dry season, is the largest of its kind in Africa.

3rd Largest uranium producer of world



## Southern African Customs Bloc, India Revive Trade Talks

The Zambezi River is the fourth-longest river in Africa (after Nile, Congo, Niger) and continent's longest east-flowing stream.

Countries covered: It flows through Angola, Zambia, Namibia, Botswana, Zimbabwe, and Mozambique.

Waterfalls: The river is known for several notable waterfalls, including Victoria Falls, one of the world's largest waterfalls

Drains into: It drains into the Indian Ocean via a 100-km-wide delta.



## Southern African Customs Bloc, India Revive Trade Talks

The Orange River is the longest river in South Africa and one of the most significant river systems in southern Africa, flowing through Lesotho, South Africa, and Namibia. Orange River drains into Atlantic Ocean.



# Southern African Customs Bloc, India Revive Trade Talks

UPSC Prelims 2020 Question:

Consider the following pairs

| Sl. No. | River   |   | Flows into   |
|---------|---------|---|--------------|
| 1.      | Mekong  | : | Andaman Sea  |
| 2.      | Thames  | : | Irish Sea    |
| 3.      | Volga   | : | Caspian Sea  |
| 4.      | Zambezi | : | Indian Ocean |

Which of the pairs given above is/are correctly matched?

1. 1 and 2 only

2. 3 only

3. 3 and 4 only

4. 1, 2 and 4 only

# Thank You